Housekeeping Health, Safety and COSHH Policy

Policy BHH-HK-01 · Version 2.0 · 12 November 2026 (replaces version 1.0 of 9 November 2026) · Applies to all housekeeping, laundry and public area cleaning staff, including agency and casual staff. Review: November 2027, or sooner if products, suppliers or the law change.

1. Purpose and scope

This policy sets out how Brandon Hall Hotel and Spa keeps housekeeping staff, guests and visitors safe: the safe use of cleaning chemicals (COSHH), hygiene and cross-contamination, linen handling, and the wider health and safety risks of housekeeping work. It also sets one cleaning standard that every member of the team follows, so that every room is cleaned the same way. It covers bedrooms, bathrooms, public areas, the laundry, the linen and chemical stores, and the housekeeping trolleys. It also covers bodily fluids and sharps found during cleaning.

2. The law and guidance

- The Control of Substances Hazardous to Health Regulations 2002 (as amended) (COSHH): assess the risks, prevent or control exposure, provide information, instruction and training, and keep controls in good order.
- The Health and Safety at Work etc. Act 1974 and the Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations 1999: a safe place of work, risk assessment, and extra care for new and expectant mothers and young workers.
- Classification, labelling and packaging of chemicals (GB CLP): the hazard pictograms and safety data sheets supplied with every product.
- The Personal Protective Equipment at Work Regulations 1992 (as amended 2022): suitable PPE provided free, with training in its use.
- The Manual Handling Operations Regulations 1992 and the Workplace (Health, Safety and Welfare) Regulations 1992: safe lifting, and floors and routes kept free of slip and trip hazards.
- The Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations 2013 (RIDDOR): reporting certain injuries, occupational diseases (including some cases of dermatitis) and dangerous occurrences.
- HSE guidance: COSHH essentials for cleaning, and Managing skin exposure risks at work (HSG262).

3. Responsibilities

Who	Responsibilities
General Manager	Makes sure this policy is resourced and followed; approves the list of chemicals the hotel uses; reviews accidents and skin-health concerns.
Head of Housekeeping / housekeeping leads	Keeps the chemical register and safety data sheets up to date; makes sure a COSHH assessment exists for every product before it is used; issues and replaces PPE; trains staff and checks they follow the rules; carries out the monthly skin checks; investigates spills, accidents and near misses.
Housekeeping and laundry staff	Complete the COSHH training before using any chemical; follow the safe-use rules and the label; wear the PPE provided; report spills, accidents, damaged PPE and any skin or breathing problems straight away.
Purchasing / suppliers	Only buy products on the approved list; obtain the current safety data sheet with every new product or change of formula.

4. Approved products, labels and safety data sheets

Only the products below may be used by the housekeeping team. They are recorded in the chemical register (Appendix A). A new product is added only after the Head of Housekeeping has obtained its safety data sheet and completed a COSHH assessment. The dilution, method, hazards and first aid for each product are taken from its label and safety data sheet, which always take priority over this table.

Product	Type	Approved use
Ecolab Diesin Max	Multipurpose bathroom and floor cleaner	Bathroom surfaces and floors
Ecolab Pro Glass Multi Surface Cleaner	Glass and multi-surface spray	Mirrors, glass and shiny surfaces (blue cloth, then buff with green)
Sysco Glass and Surface Spray	Glass and surface spray	Mirrors, glass and shiny surfaces (blue cloth, then buff with green)
Ecolab Toilet Cleaner	Toilet cleaner	Toilets and WCs only (red / pink cloth)
Sysco Toilet Cleaner	Toilet cleaner	Toilets and WCs only (red / pink cloth)
Ecolab Mould Ex	Mould remover	Mould on sealant and grout only — ventilate, gloves and eye protection
Topclin Mould Remover Spray	Mould remover	Mould on sealant and grout only — ventilate, gloves and eye protection
Brakes Bleach	Bleach	Only when your supervisor tells you to. Never mixed with anything
Descaler (tarnish remover)	Descaler	Limescale and tarnish on taps, shower heads and chrome
Ecolab Pro White Cotton Air Freshener	Air freshener	A light spray into the air after cleaning — never to hide a smell
Sysco Keystone Air Freshener	Air freshener	A light spray into the air after cleaning — never to hide a smell
Fairy Liquid	Washing-up liquid	Washing tea and coffee cups at the designated sink

- A current safety data sheet (SDS) for every product is kept in the SDS folder in the chemical store, with a copy uploaded to HosFIRE → Documents.
- Always use the product made for the job. Never use a product for a purpose it is not approved for, and never bring in products from home.
- Every container must be labelled. Unlabelled or unidentified products are removed from use and returned to the Head of Housekeeping.

5. COSHH assessments

Each product has a written COSHH assessment (Appendix B) that records: what it is used for, its hazards (from the SDS), who could be harmed, how it is diluted and applied, the controls and PPE required, storage, first aid, spill and disposal arrangements. Assessments are reviewed every year, when a product or method changes, or after an incident. Staff must read the assessment for each product they use.

6. Safe-use rules for everyone

- Read the label before use and follow the dilution and method on the label or dispenser. More chemical does not clean better.
- Never mix chemicals or use two products on the same surface without rinsing in between (see section 8).
- Only decant into the correct labelled bottle for that product. Never use food or drink containers.
- Spray onto the cloth where possible; never spray towards your face, other people, guests or food.
- Ventilate: open the window or switch on the extractor fan when cleaning bathrooms and when using any strong product.
- Close lids immediately after use and wipe up drips straight away.
- Aerosols are flammable: keep away from heat and naked flames, and never puncture or burn them.
- Wash and dry hands after removing gloves and before eating, drinking or smoking.

7. Personal protective equipment (PPE)

Task	PPE required
General cleaning with diluted products	Disposable or reusable gloves suitable for the chemical (nitrile is the default)
Toilets, bathrooms, bins and anything soiled	Gloves; apron where splashing is likely
Diluting, decanting or handling concentrates	Chemical-resistant gloves, eye protection (goggles or safety glasses), apron
Strong toilet cleaners, descalers, limescale or drain products	Chemical-resistant gloves and eye protection
Spraying at or above head height	Eye protection
Bodily fluids and sharps	Body fluid kit: gloves, apron, absorbent, disinfectant; sharps kit and tongs for needles
Laundry chemicals (topping up or changing drums)	Only trained staff; chemical-resistant gloves and eye protection

PPE is provided free and replaced when worn or damaged. Staff check PPE before use and report any that is missing or does not fit. Gloves are not a substitute for safe working; they are the last line of defence.

8. Never mix — dangerous combinations

Never mix	Because
Brakes Bleach, Ecolab Mould Ex or Topclin Mould Remover + Ecolab or Sysco Toilet Cleaner, or the descaler	Bleach-type products and toilet cleaners or descalers can react and release a poisonous gas that damages the lungs. Check each product's SDS for its active ingredients.
Bleach + glass cleaners, air fresheners or any other cleaner	Unpredictable reactions; weakens the product and can release gas
Any two products in the same bottle, bucket, toilet, bath or sink	Use one product at a time and rinse with water in between

Never mix	Because
Mould remover and toilet cleaner in the same bathroom at the same time	Finish, rinse and ventilate with one before using the other

If anyone notices a strong or unusual smell, or feels dizzy, short of breath or has stinging eyes: stop, leave the room, close the door, keep others out and tell the supervisor or duty manager.

9. Storage

- All chemicals are kept in the locked, ventilated chemical (COSHH) store, which only housekeeping staff can access.
- Containers are stored upright with lids closed, at low level for heavy or corrosive products, on spill trays where possible, and away from heat, direct sunlight and food.
- Acid products and chlorine (bleach) products are stored apart. Aerosols are kept away from heat sources.
- Only the quantity needed for the shift goes on the trolley, in correctly labelled bottles. Trolleys are never left unattended in corridors or open rooms with chemicals accessible, and are returned to the store at the end of each shift.
- No chemicals are ever left in guest rooms, public toilets or other areas guests can reach.
- Linen cupboards and chemical stores are not used to store food, drink or personal belongings.

10. Colour-coded microfibre cloths

Colour coding stops germs being carried from one area to another. Every trolley carries all the colours below, and the colours are never swapped.

Cloth	Used for
Red / pink	Toilets and WCs only — never anywhere else
Orange	Bathrooms: basins, bathtubs, tiles and shower screens
Blue	Wet cleaning of mirrors, with the glass spray
Green	Buffing mirrors dry to remove smudges and residue
Yellow	Dusting bedroom surfaces and furniture
Tea towel	Clean, designated tea towels only — for washing and drying tea and coffee cups

- Cloths are laundered after every shift. Used or heavily soiled cloths are replaced with clean ones straight away.
- Guest towels, pillowcases and bed linen are never used as cleaning cloths, for any task.

11. Hygiene and cross-contamination

- The designated cloth is used for each area: toilets, bathrooms, mirrors and bedroom surfaces each have their own colour, so the toilet cloth never touches the basin, the bedroom or the cups.
- Staff wash or sanitise their hands and change gloves when moving between cleaning tasks — always after cleaning the toilet, and before making the bed, handling clean linen or touching cups.
- Tea and coffee cups are washed with Fairy Liquid and hot water at the designated sink — never in the guest bathroom basin — and dried with a clean, designated tea towel.
- All housekeeping chemical and storage cupboard doors are closed and secured after every use.

12. Clean and dirty linen

- Clean and dirty linen are kept apart at all times. Dirty linen goes straight into the laundry bag; clean linen stays on the clean shelf of the trolley, covered where possible.
- Clean linen is never placed on the floor. Any linen that touches the floor is sent to the laundry and replaced.
- Linen is shaken out gently when a bed is stripped, to check for guest items and sharps. Mattresses and seams are checked for stains and signs of bed bugs, which are reported immediately.
- Stained, damaged or contaminated linen is bagged separately and reported. Linen soiled with bodily fluids is handled as set out under bodily fluids, sharps and waste.

13. Cleaning procedures and accountability

- Every room is cleaned to the procedure in guide BHH-HK-02: the 5-step loop (assign, clean, check, report, release) and the cleaning sequence — top to bottom, dry to wet, clean to dirty, toilet last and vacuum last.
- Staff follow the hotel procedure rather than personal cleaning habits, so that every room is the same standard and nobody is put at risk.
- Maintenance faults (leaking taps, blown bulbs, damaged fabrics, faulty equipment) are reported with the room number before the room is released. A room with a safety fault stays closed.
- Anyone who sees an incorrect cleaning practice — the wrong cloth, mixed chemicals, linen on the floor — politely stops it if it is safe to do so and tells the supervisor, so it can be put right and retrained. This is part of everyone's job and is not a matter of blame.
- Supervisors inspect rooms with the room inspection checklist and address repeated issues through coaching and retraining.

14. General health and safety in housekeeping

Risk	How we control it
Manual handling	Push trolleys, don't pull; keep them light enough to manoeuvre. Bend the knees when lifting; don't overfill linen bags; two people to turn or move mattresses and heavy furniture.
Slips, trips and falls	Wet floor signs out while floors are wet; spills wiped up straight away; cables and linen bags kept out of walkways; sensible, enclosed non-slip shoes.
Working at height	Never stand on beds, chairs, baths or furniture. Use the step stool provided for high dusting, or report the task to maintenance.
Electrical equipment	Check vacuum cleaners and leads before use; never use damaged equipment — take it out of use and report it. Never touch electrics with wet hands.
Sharps and broken glass	Never pick up needles by hand or push rubbish down with hands or feet. Use the sharps kit; wrap broken glass before binning.
Personal safety and room entry	Knock and announce twice before entering; keep the door open while working; master keys stay on you; never let anyone into a room. If a guest behaves inappropriately, leave and tell the supervisor.
Fire	Know your escape routes and assembly point; never prop open fire doors or block exits with trolleys; follow the Housekeeping Fire Safety Manual.

15. Spills, leaks and emergencies

- Small spill: put on gloves and eye protection, keep people away, put out a wet floor sign, absorb with paper or the spill kit, bag the waste and tell the supervisor.
- Large spill, leak or fumes: leave the area, close the door, keep others away and tell the supervisor or duty manager immediately. Do not attempt to clean up alone.
- A spill kit, eyewash and the first aid kit are kept near the chemical store. Their location is shown to every new starter.

16. First aid

Contact	Action
Eyes	Rinse immediately with clean running water or eyewash for at least 15 minutes, holding the eyelids open. Get first aid and medical advice.
Skin	Remove contaminated clothing; rinse the skin with plenty of water. Get first aid if irritation continues.
Swallowed	Do not make the person sick. Rinse the mouth with water. Get medical help (NHS 111, or 999 if the person is unwell).
Breathed in	Move to fresh air and keep the person calm. Call 999 if they have difficulty breathing.

Always take the product label or the safety data sheet to the first aider, doctor or hospital. Record every incident in the accident book.

17. Skin care and health checks

- Housekeeping involves frequent wet work, which can cause dermatitis. Staff wear gloves, dry their hands thoroughly and use the after-work moisturising cream provided.
- The Head of Housekeeping (or a trained responsible person) carries out a simple skin check of each team member every month and records it (Appendix C). Anyone with redness, dryness, itching, cracking or a rash is referred for advice, and the cause is investigated.
- Staff tell their supervisor about any skin condition, asthma, allergy or breathing problem so that extra precautions can be taken.

18. Staff who need extra protection

- New and expectant mothers: a specific risk assessment is completed as soon as the hotel is told, and tasks or products changed where necessary.
- Young workers (under 18): do not handle concentrates or the most hazardous products, and are supervised until trained and competent.
- Staff with asthma, allergies or skin conditions: tasks and products reviewed with them.

19. Bodily fluids, sharps and waste

- Bodily fluids (blood, vomit, urine, faeces) are cleaned using the body fluid kit, following its instructions, while wearing gloves and an apron. Contaminated linen is bagged and labelled for separate laundering.
- Needles and sharp objects are never picked up by hand. Use the sharps kit or tongs and place in a sharps container, or call the supervisor. Never compress rubbish with hands or feet.
- Empty chemical containers are rinsed (where the label allows) and disposed of as directed by the label or supplier. Chemicals are never poured into drains other than as part of normal diluted use.

20. Guests and the public

- Wet floor signs are put out while floors are wet and removed once dry.
- Trolleys are parked so they do not block corridors or fire exits, and never left with chemicals accessible to children.
- Guest rooms are ventilated after cleaning, and no product residue is left on surfaces guests touch.

21. Laundry

- Laundry machines use automatic chemical dosing. Only trained staff change or top up chemical drums, wearing gloves and eye protection.
- Dosing lines, drums and the laundry chemical store are checked weekly for leaks, and faults are reported to maintenance and the supplier.
- Fire safety rules for the laundry (lint filters, cool-down cycles, oily linen) are in the Housekeeping Fire Safety Manual.

22. Training

- Every member of the housekeeping and laundry team completes the online course Housekeeping standards: COSHH, hygiene and room cleaning before their first shift, and again every 12 months. It covers our products, never mixing chemicals, PPE, storage, the colour-coded cloths, hygiene, linen, the cleaning sequence, reporting faults and accountability, and ends with a 20-question check (pass mark 16) and a signed certificate, recorded automatically in HosFIRE → Housekeeping.
- Practical training: each new starter is trained in a real room by the Head of Housekeeping or a supervisor using guide BHH-HK-02, and is shown the chemical store, the SDS folder, the products and cloths on the trolley, the PPE, the spill kit, the eyewash and the body fluid and sharps kits.
- Refresher training is also given when a new product or method is introduced, after an incident, or when an inspection shows the standard is not being followed.

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23. Accidents, ill health and reporting

All accidents, near misses, chemical exposures, spills and suspected work-related ill health (including skin problems) are reported to the supervisor and recorded in the accident book the same day. The duty manager decides whether the incident is reportable under RIDDOR and, if so, reports it to the HSE within the required time.

24. Monitoring and review

The Head of Housekeeping checks the chemical store, cupboard doors, trolleys, cloths, labelling, linen handling and PPE every month as part of the housekeeping audit, and reviews room inspection results for repeated issues. This policy, the chemical register and the COSHH assessments are reviewed every year and whenever products, suppliers or working methods change.

Approved by	Job title	Signature	Date

Appendix A — Chemical register (approved products)

The products currently used by housekeeping are listed. Complete the hazards, dilution, PPE and SDS columns from each product's label and safety data sheet, and add laundry and any other products. Keep this register up to date whenever a product changes.

Product type	Product name and supplier	Used for	Hazards (pictograms)	Dilution	PPE	SDS on file / COSHH assessment date
Multipurpose bathroom and floor cleaner	Ecolab Diesin Max	Bathroom surfaces and floors		As label		
Glass and multi-surface spray	Ecolab Pro Glass Multi Surface Cleaner	Mirrors, glass and shiny surfaces		As label		
Glass and surface spray	Sysco Glass and Surface Spray	Mirrors, glass and shiny surfaces		As label		
Toilet cleaner	Ecolab Toilet Cleaner	Toilets and WCs only		As label		
Toilet cleaner	Sysco Toilet Cleaner	Toilets and WCs only		As label		
Mould remover	Ecolab Mould Ex	Mould on sealant and grout only		As label		
Mould remover	Topclin Mould Remover Spray	Mould on sealant and grout only		As label		
Bleach	Brakes Bleach	Only when your supervisor tells you to. Never mixed with anything		As label		
Descaler	Descaler (tarnish remover)	Limescale and tarnish on taps, shower heads and chrome		As label		
Air freshener	Ecolab Pro White Cotton Air Freshener	A light spray into the air after cleaning		As label		
Air freshener	Sysco Keystone Air Freshener	A light spray into the air after cleaning		As label		
Washing-up liquid	Fairy Liquid	Washing tea and coffee cups at the designated sink		As label		

Product type	Product name and supplier	Used for	Hazards (pictograms)	Dilution	PPE	SDS on file / COSHH assessment date
Laundry detergent (auto-dosed)						
Laundry destainer / conditioner						
Hand soap / sanitiser						
Body fluid / spill granules						

Appendix B — COSHH assessment form

One form per product. Keep with the safety data sheet and upload to HosFIRE → Documents.

Item	Details
Product name, supplier and SDS date	
Used for (task and area)	
How it is used (dilution, dispenser, spray / cloth / mop)	
Hazards from the SDS (pictograms and hazard statements)	
Who could be harmed (staff, guests, others) and how (skin, eyes, breathing, swallowing)	
How often and how long it is used	
Control measures (ventilation, dispenser, ready-to-use, no mixing, storage)	
PPE required	
Storage requirements	
Spill procedure	
First aid (from the SDS)	
Disposal of product and empty containers	
Health surveillance needed? (e.g. skin checks)	
Risk level after controls (low / medium / high)	
Further actions needed	
Assessed by / date	
Review date	

Appendix C — Monthly skin check record

Look at both hands, between the fingers and the wrists. Record: OK, or describe redness, dryness, itching, cracking, blisters or rash and the action taken (advice, glove change, referral).

Date	Name	Result	Details and action taken	Checked by

Appendix D — Housekeeping training record (paper backup)

Use only if the online course cannot be completed. The online course is the main record (HosFIRE → Housekeeping).

Name	Date	Trained by	Staff signature	Shown store, SDS, PPE, spill and body fluid kits